

Attitudes that last

Facilitating *stable* support for
democracy



Picture someone from
your own life...



... who you want to reach with
your pro-democracy campaign

Exposure to your campaign



Support for Democracy

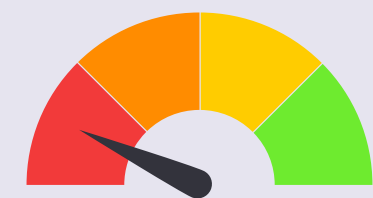


Anti-Democratic Influence



Anti-Democratic Influence

3 months later



Support for Democracy

Why did the campaign not provide
protection from antidemocratic
messaging?

A lot of 'validated' pro-democracy campaigns ...

... focus only on making people *like* democracy

- Telling people why democracy is a good thing
- Correcting misperceptions about democracy
-



however...

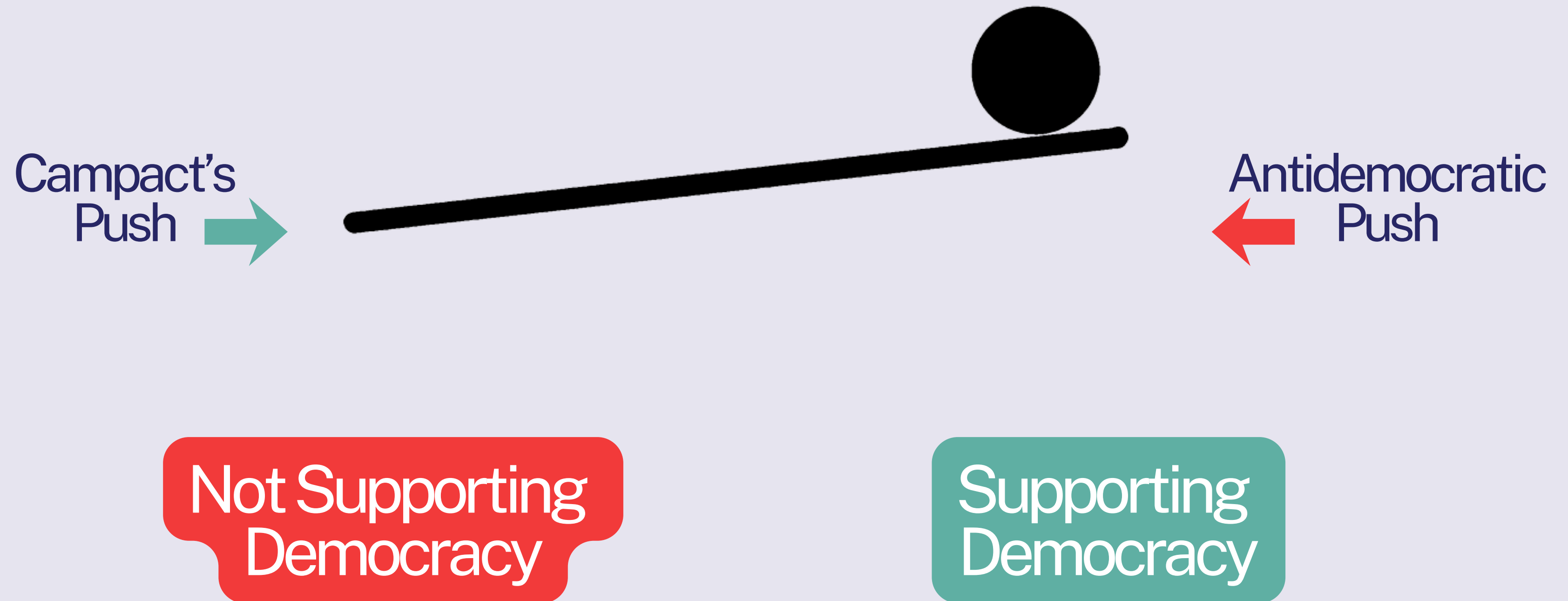
When asking people ...

“How much do you support democracy?”



... although more supportive
immediately after the campaign, their
support decreases again over time.

Unstable Support



Why are the risks for Campact?

01

Broader goal of democratic resilience is jeopardized

02

More donated money required for constant repetitions of campaigns

03

More *effort* and organizational capital spent on potentially only temporally effective campaigns.

Instability



Support for
Democracy

Campact



So, what's going on?

Current campaigns are often only assessed in terms of whether support for democracy increased. However, this leaves out an important component ...

Support for Democracy

An attitude

Two dimensions:

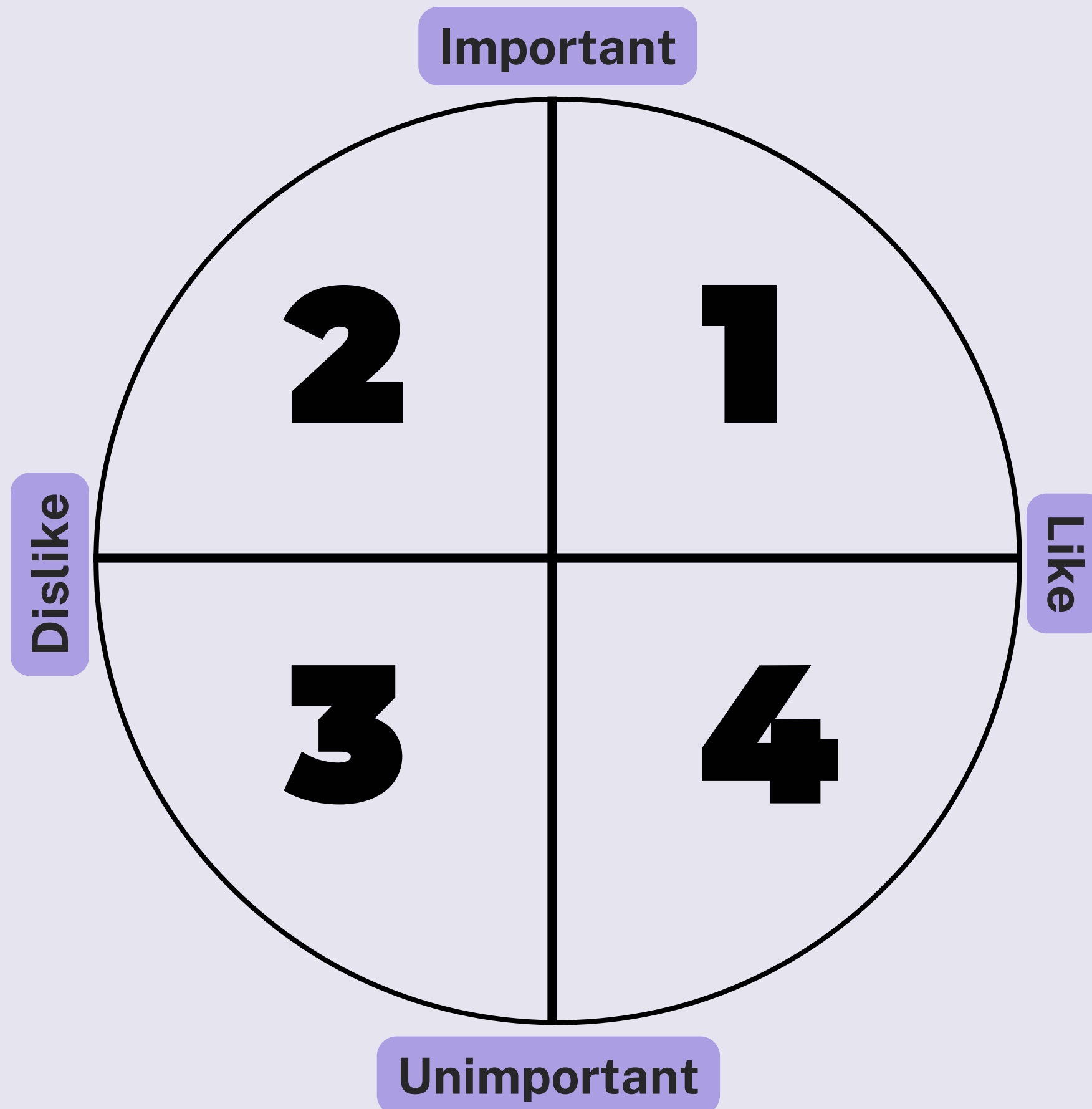


Whether you like something

Whether it is important to you

Democracy is a good thing AND
you care a lot about it

1

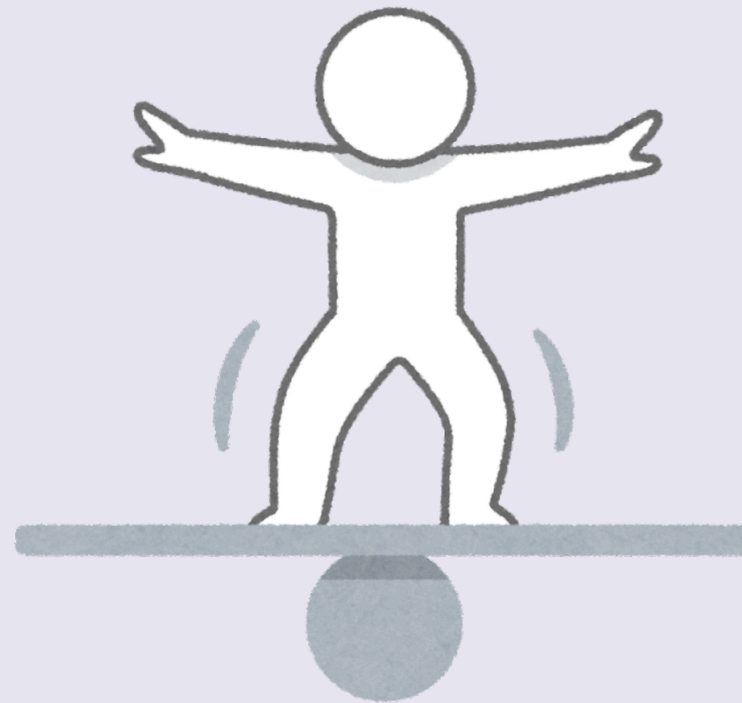


(Fazio, 2007)

Important Attitudes

—— being attached to something/caring a lot ——

One consequence of attitude importance



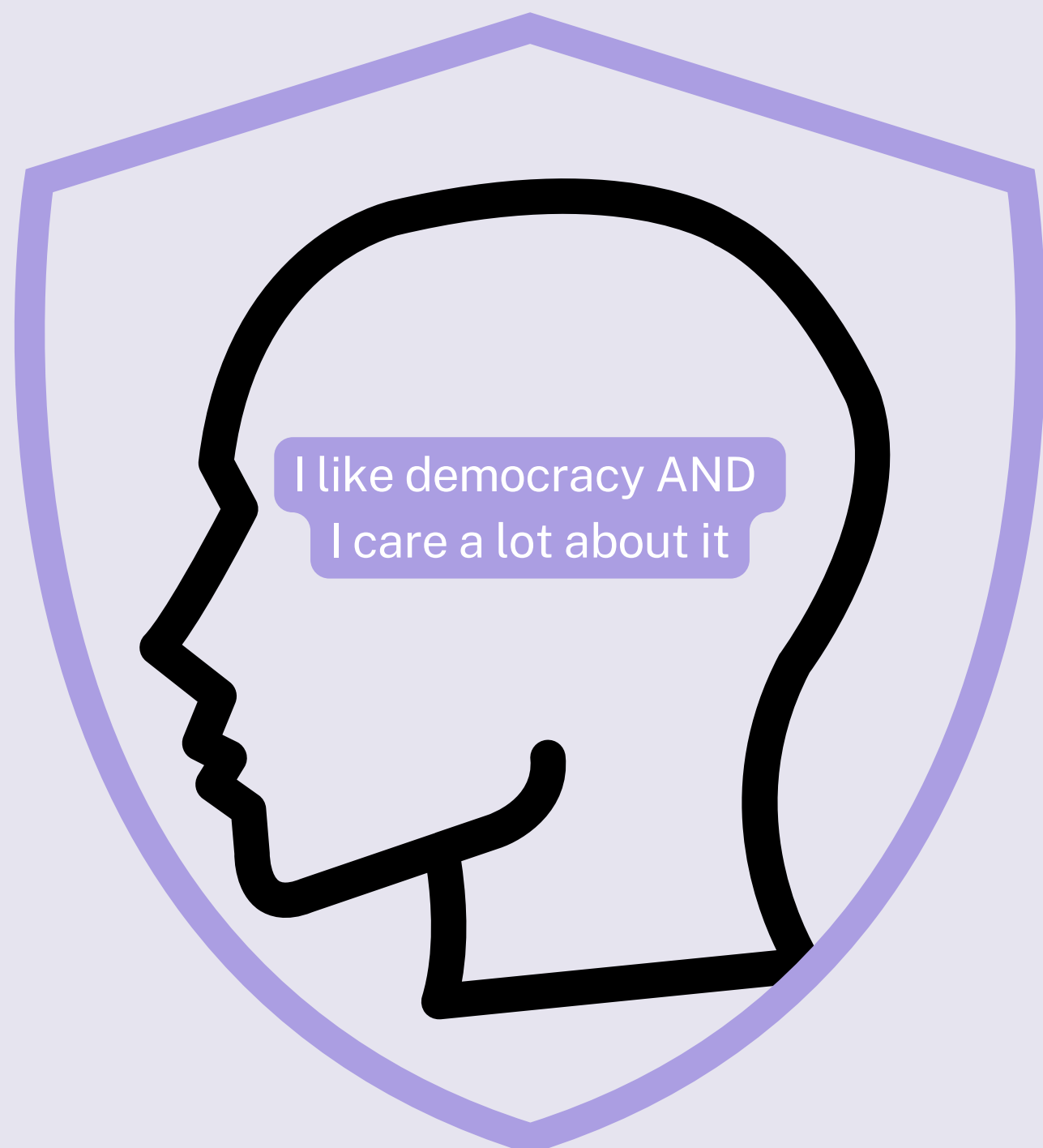
Stability

—— resistance to change (e.g., persuasion) ——

Based on research from other domains ...

... liking democracy and finding it personally
important could make support for
democracy durable.

Anti-Democratic
Influence



Economic
Deprivation

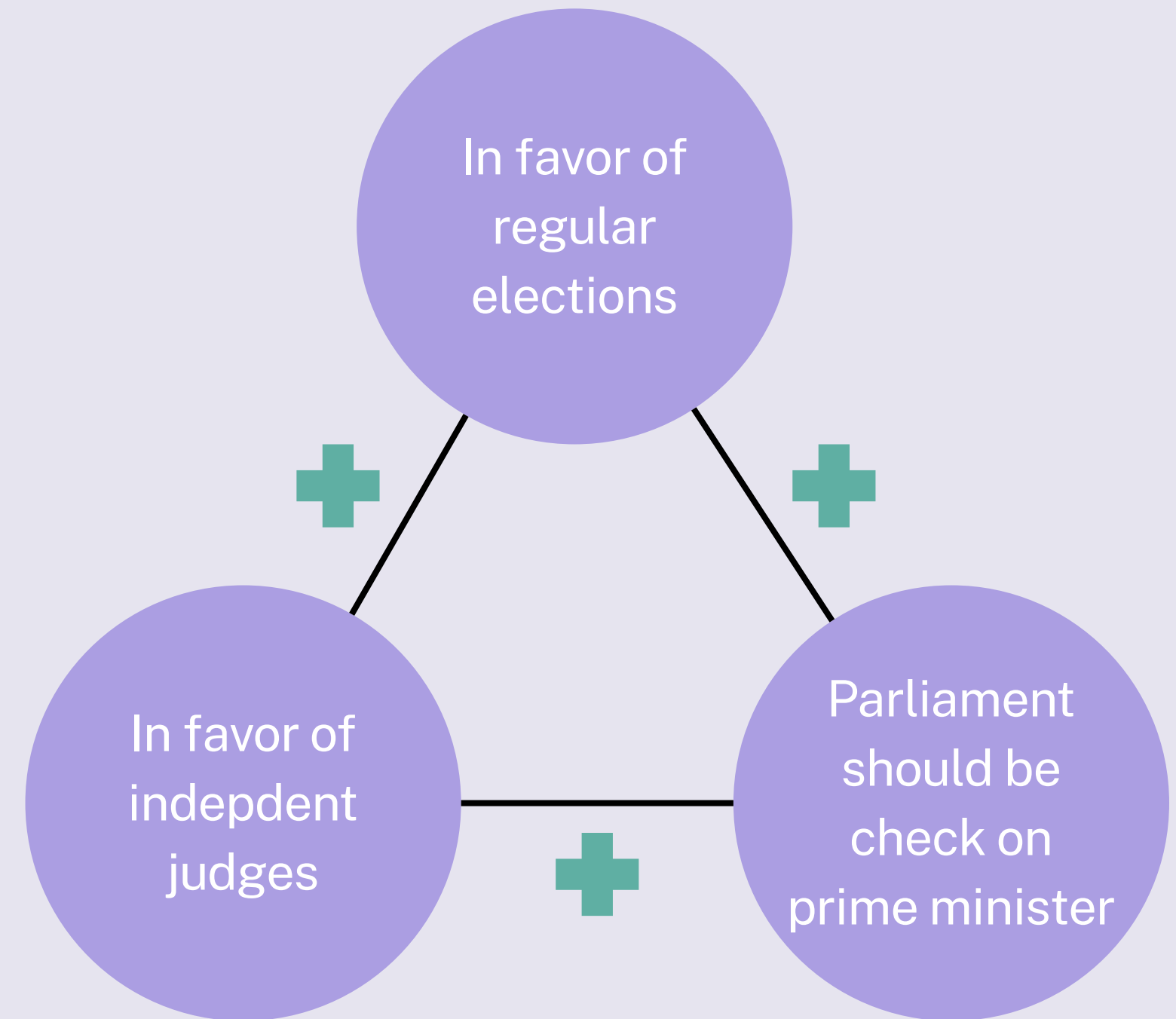
Why?

Why is finding democracy important a potential solution?

Attitudes can be considered networks of mutually reinforcing beliefs.

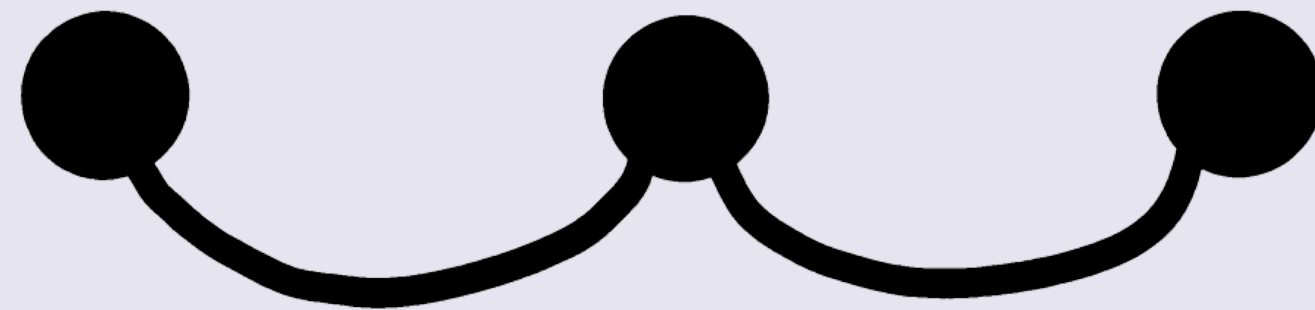
The stronger they reinforce each other, the more stable the overall attitude is.

When something is important to us, beliefs have *stronger* connections.



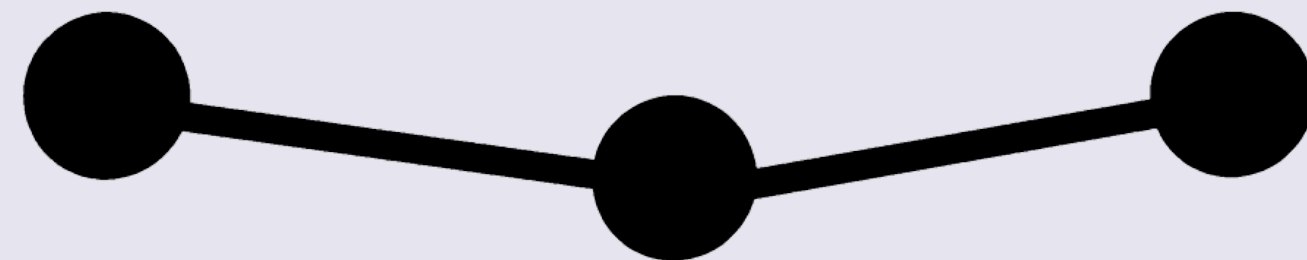
(Dalege et al., 2016)

Little importance ...



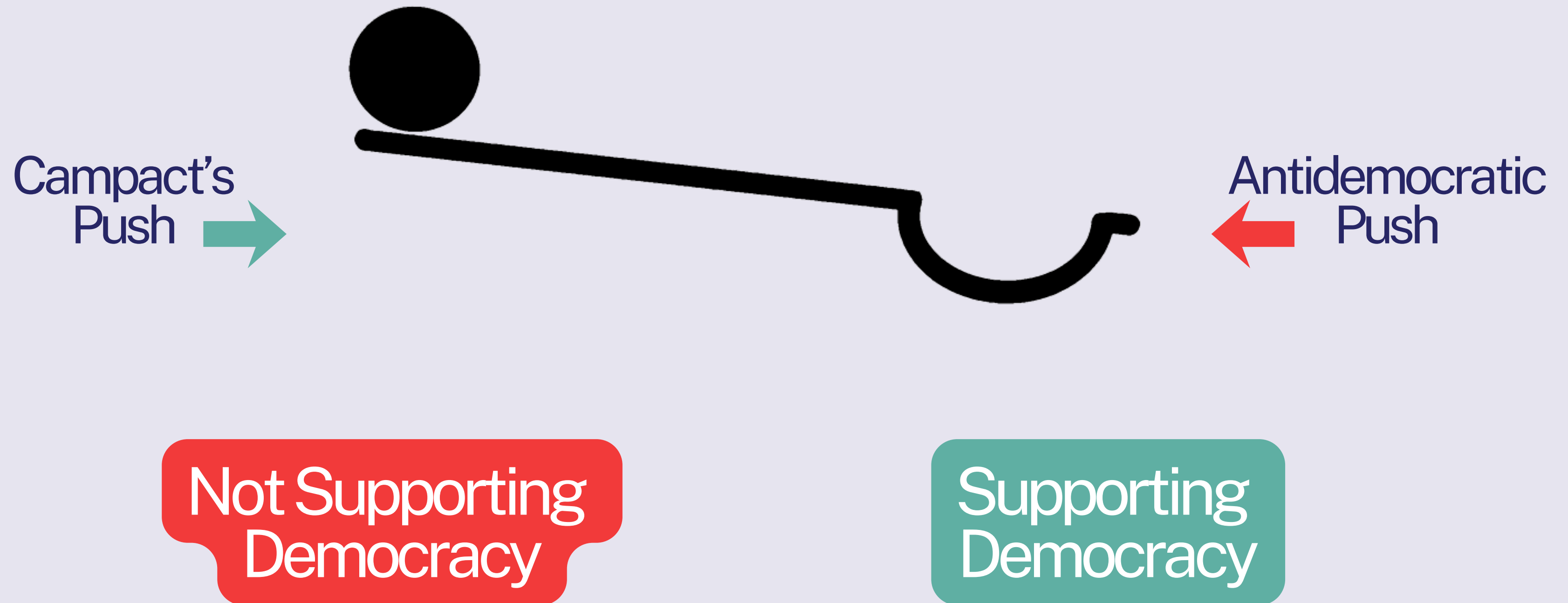
... weak links

Much importance...



... strong links

Stable Support



Key Takeaway

A Pro-Democracy Campaign ...

should aim to make people support democracy AND also find it personally important because importance makes support *durable*.



Why are the benefits for Campact?

01

Stimulating lasting support for democracy which, in the long term, can contribute to democratic resilience

02

More pro-democratic return per donated Euro

03

More effort and organizational capital spent on effective campaigns

How?

How can Campact make people personally care about democracy?

Democratic collapse threats are a promising strategy (how are people's lives adversely affected by democratic erosion?). See Voelkel et al. (2024).

When in doubt, pilot your campaign's effects – assess changes in support for AND importance of democracy.



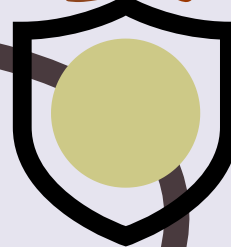
Remember the person you pictured?



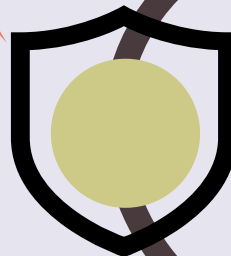
Exposure to your campaign



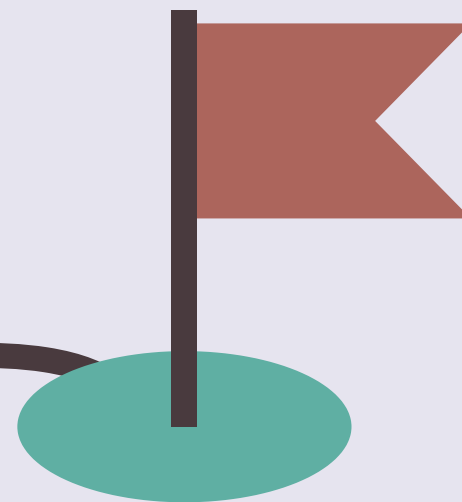
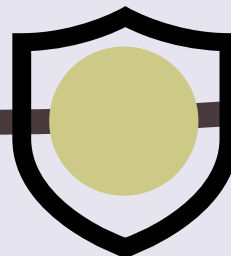
Support for Democracy



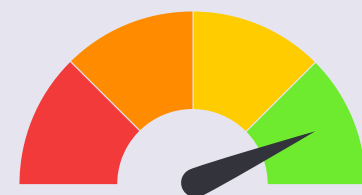
Anti-Democratic Influence



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3 months later



Support for Democracy

Thank you very much!



Some discussion points ...

How could you apply these insights to your campaigns?

Do you think an implementation into your campaigns is feasible?

Are you planning to actually implement these insights?

References

- Dalege, J., Borsboom, D., Van Harreveld, F., Van Den Berg, H., Conner, M., & Van Der Maas, H. L. J. (2016). Toward a formalized account of attitudes: The Causal Attitude Network (CAN) model. *Psychological Review*, 123(1), 2–22. <https://doi.org/10.1037/a0039802>
- Dalege, J., Borsboom, D., Van Harreveld, F., & Van Der Maas, H. L. J. (2019). A network perspective on attitude strength: Testing the connectivity hypothesis. *Social Psychological and Personality Science*, 10(6), 746–756. <https://doi.org/10.1177/1948550618781062>
- Maas, H. L. J. van der. (2024). *Complex systems research in psychology*. The Santa Fe Institute Press. <https://santafeinstitute.github.io/ComplexPsych/>
- Voelkel, J. G., Stagnaro, M. N., Chu, J. Y., Pink, S. L., Mernyk, J. S., Redekopp, C., Ghezae, I., Cashman, M., Adjodah, D., Allen, L. G., Allis, L. V., Baleria, G., Ballantyne, N., Van Bavel, J. J., Blunden, H., Braley, A., Bryan, C. J., Celniker, J. B., Cikara, M., ... Willer, R. (2024). Megastudy testing 25 treatments to reduce antidemocratic attitudes and partisan animosity. *Science*, 386(6719), eadh4764.